

when they get to that part of the curriculum, they will get the new sequence automatically. In other words, tools like School of One enable teachers to work in much smaller batches, to the benefit of their students. (And, as tools reach wide-scale adoption, successful experiments by individual teachers can be rolled out district-, city-, or even nationwide.) This approach is having an impact and earning accolades. Time magazine recently included School of One in its “most innovative ideas” list; it was the only educational organization to make the list.⁵

THE LARGE-BATCH DEATH SPIRAL

Small batches pose a challenge to managers steeped in traditional notions of productivity and progress, because they believe that functional specialization is more efficient for expert workers.

Imagine you're a product designer overseeing a new product and you need to produce thirty individual design drawings. It probably seems that the most efficient way to work is in seclusion, by yourself, producing the designs one by one. Then, when you're done with all of them, you pass the drawings on to the engineering team and let them work. In other words, you work in large batches.

From the point of view of individual efficiency, working in large batches makes sense. It also has other benefits: it promotes skill building, makes it easier to hold individual contributors accountable, and, most important, allows experts to work without interruption. At least that's the theory. Unfortunately, reality seldom works out that way.

Consider our hypothetical example. After passing thirty design drawings to engineering, the designer is free to turn his or her attention to the next project. But remember the problems that came up during the envelope-stuffing exercise. What happens when engineering has questions about how the drawings are supposed to work? What if some of the drawings are unclear? What if something goes wrong when engineering attempts to use the drawings?